Albert de Rochas d'Aiglun — *L'Extériorisation de la sensibilité* (1895)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Albert de Rochas (1837–1914), who pursued one borderland of inquiry for nearly thirty years. Beginning with Les Forces non définies in 1887, he wrote book after book on hypnotism, telekinesis, magnetic emanations, reincarnation and spirit photography. His study of 1895 set out, experimentally and historically, the strange claim at the centre of this edition, with diagrams of the layers of sensibility. English-language writers have not neglected him; they have summarised him at second hand, citing his French volumes as French. This edition is dedicated to letting English readers meet de Rochas himself, rather than other people's accounts of him.

The author's own terms

De Rochas documents the externalisation of sensibility: a hypnotised subject feeling a stimulus applied at a distance from the body, as if sensibility itself had been placed outside the body.

The story

For nearly thirty years, Albert de Rochas (1837–1914) wrote about the borderland where the nineteenth century's science met its mysteries: hypnotism,

telekinesis, "magnetic emanations," reincarnation, and spirit photography. He began with *Les Forces non définies* in 1887. Telekinesis means movement at a distance, and magnetic emanations, in the language of his time, were influences supposed to pass from a person outward. These were his subjects, pursued in book after book.

The book at the centre of this dossier is *L'Extériorisation de la sensibilité*, published in 1895, a study, experimental and historical, of the externalisation of sensibility. Its claim, documented in its pages, is a strange one stated plainly here as the dossier records it: a hypnotised subject feeling a stimulus applied at a distance from the body. Sensibility — the capacity to feel — was said to be exteriorised, placed outside the body itself, so that what was done at that distance was felt by the subject.

A companion volume followed. *L'Extériorisation de la motricité*, of 1896, which documents the Palladino committee work, concerns the externalisation of motricity, of movement rather than feeling. Its fourth edition runs to 630 pages.

De Rochas has not lacked writers about him in English. What he has lacked is translation. English-language writing about him summarises him at second hand, citing the French volumes as French. A reader can therefore learn what others say de Rochas found, but cannot read his own experimental and historical account in English in any edition found by this research.

The work and what survives

L'Extériorisation de la sensibilité is available in reprint at 278 pages, in French, and is stated to be public domain in the United States. Its early editions are pre-1923, and the author died in 1914. Even so, edition copyright is to be checked per edition when an edition is prepared, as with all reviewer items. Different editions can carry different positions, and a general statement does not replace that check.

An Internet Archive-derived copy of *Sensibilité* is listed via OnRead. That listing must be treated with care. The IA identifier is to be re-verified at acquisition; the listing alone is not the scan anchor. In other words, the listing shows that a copy is said to exist, but it does not yet pin down the scan from which an edition would be made.

Its English fortunes

No English translation found after research.

The supporting detail in the record is specific: English-language writing about Rochas summarises him at second hand, citing the French volumes as French, for example a hypnosis survey citing the 1907 6th edition. Citation of that kind keeps the original at arm's length. It names the French book as authority, while giving the English reader a summary instead of the book.

What completing it would take

The right beginning is *Sensibilité* alone. It is one self-contained experimental and historical volume, about 278 pages, written in clear expository French, with diagrams of the "layers" of sensibility. Its size and its self-contained shape make it completable on its own.

Motricité is a second, larger, Palladino-heavy volume, and it is a separate decision. Its 630 pages, in its fourth edition, and its committee subject matter raise questions of scope that do not need to be settled in order to begin with *Sensibilité*. Keeping the two decisions separate protects both books: the first can be completed whole, and the second can be judged on its own record if and when it is taken up.

Sources

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